

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

PLAY – THE OYSTER AND THE PEARL

by
William Saroyan

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1. About the Play and the Playwright

The Oyster and the Pearl is a short one-act play by the American writer **William Saroyan** (1908–1981). Saroyan was born in Fresno, California, to Armenian immigrant parents, and much of his writing celebrates ordinary, poor but warm-hearted people who find joy in simple things. He is best known for his play *The Time of Your Life*, which won the Pulitzer Prize for Drama in 1940 – a prize he famously refused – and for the novel *The Human Comedy*.

The play is a gentle **comedy with a serious undertone**. On the surface it is a funny afternoon in a barber shop; underneath it is about hope, belief, kindness and the difference between facts and faith. The whole action takes place in one room on one Saturday, so it follows the dramatic unities of **place** and **time**.

Quick facts

Title	The Oyster and the Pearl
Author	William Saroyan (American-Armenian dramatist, short-story writer, novelist)
Genre	One-act play; light comedy with a serious message
Setting	Harry Van Dusen's barber shop, O.K.-by-the-Sea, California (population 909); 1953; one Saturday
Protagonist	Harry Van Dusen, the barber
Antagonist	Miss Vivian McCutcheon (opposing outlook); deeper forces: poverty and family quarrels
Central symbols	The oyster (hardship, hidden hope) and the pearl (hope and faith)
Central theme	Hope, kindness and taking life easy matter more than cold facts and money

2. Characters

Character	Description and role
Harry Van Dusen	The barber and the wise, kind centre of the play. He has lived in the town for twenty-four years and follows a "take-it-easy" philosophy. He always wears a hat, reads books, and treats the shop as a place for talk rather than money. He quietly arranges the happy ending.
Clay Larrabee	A nine- or ten-year-old boy who trims Harry's hair in exchange for his own free haircuts. His father has left home, and Clay hopes money will bring him back. He finds the oyster and firmly believes it holds a pearl.
Miss Vivian McCutcheon	The pretty new schoolteacher. She is logical, proud of "the truth" and eager to be taken seriously. She wants a poodle haircut to look plain and fit in, and she argues that the oyster must be opened to show there is no pearl.
Clark Larrabee	Clay's father, a decent man who is ashamed that he cannot provide more. After quarrels with his wife he has gone off to work in Salinas. He secretly leaves thirty dollars for Clay and later returns home for a weekend after reading the newspaper ad.

Character	Description and role
The Man (a writer)	A well-dressed stranger of about forty, driving to Hollywood. He stops for a haircut, listens, then buys the oyster for three hundred dollars, saying the whole thing is a pearl.
Roxanna Larrabee	Clay's sister, who collects shells and supports her brother.
Greeley	Clay's young friend, who carries a bottle of sea water and believes it is full of living things.
Judge Applegarth	A local beachcomber, nicknamed "Judge" because he once judged pigs at a fair. He complains that the sea no longer washes up anything good.
Wozzeck	The town watch repairer, who also sells imitation jewellery. He is called to open the oyster and is left bewildered by the sale.

3. Setting

- **Place:** Harry Van Dusen's old-fashioned barber shop in **O.K.-by-the-Sea**, a tiny seaside town in California. The shop is crowded with things washed up by the sea – shells, driftwood, rope, a life jacket – plus many books.
- **Time:** 1953 (Greeley says so in the play), on a Saturday.
- **Mood:** relaxed, humorous and warm, with a thread of sadness about a family in trouble.
- **Why it matters:** the town's name suggests that life is not perfect but is "O.K." if one takes it easy; the sea nearby stands for life and its endless surprises; the poor but cheerful townspeople prove that wealth is not only money.

4. Summary of the Play

On a Saturday morning in the barber shop of O.K.-by-the-Sea, young **Clay Larrabee** is trimming barber **Harry Van Dusen's** hair. Harry explains his easy-going philosophy of life. Clay confesses that his father left home a month ago after a quarrel over money, and that he wants money to bring his father back and to buy his mother a present. The family has placed an advertisement in the newspaper, hoping he will read it.

The new schoolteacher, **Miss McCutcheon**, enters. She is unhappy with the town's carefree children and is thinking of leaving. She asks Harry for a poodle haircut so that she will look plain and serious. Harry refuses, believing her natural look needs no change. She leaves angry.

Clay's father, **Clark Larrabee**, then slips in, admits he has left his wife, and gives Harry thirty dollars to pass to Clay without revealing the source. Harry hands him the day's paper containing the family's advertisement. Soon after, a **writer** on his way to Hollywood comes in for a haircut.

Clay arrives with Miss McCutcheon, Greeley and Roxanna. He has found an **oyster** at Black Rock and is sure it holds a pearl worth three hundred dollars. Miss McCutcheon insists the oyster be opened to teach him reality, since only one oyster in a million holds a pearl. Harry sends the children to fetch Wozzeck and tells her the real story: Clay does not want money for itself, he wants his father home. Harry suggests that Clay believes in the pearl just as all people believe in something to keep going.

The writer, who has been listening, **buys the oyster for three hundred dollars**, saying the whole thing is a pearl. Clay goes home happy to give the money to his mother. Clark, having seen the advertisement, returns and says he will go home for the weekend. Miss McCutcheon comes back neatly dressed, hears that “there was a pearl”, and leaves puzzled without her haircut. Clark decides he cannot abandon his son, plans a fishing trip with Clay and invites Harry. Harry laughs it off as a little fun with the new teacher and jokes about the poodle haircut.

5. Protagonist and Antagonist

Protagonist

Harry Van Dusen is the protagonist. He is the character who acts: he shields Clay’s hope, refuses to cut Miss McCutcheon’s hair, hands Clark the advertisement and guides the writer’s purchase of the oyster. His goal is simple and noble – to help a troubled family and to keep a child’s faith alive. Clay is the heart of the problem, but Harry is the one who drives the solution.

- Wise, generous and humorous; values people over profit.
- Believes in the “take-it-easy” way of living and in kindness over cold facts.
- Does not mind bending the truth for a good cause.

Antagonist

The play has no villain. The character who opposes Harry’s outlook is **Miss McCutcheon**, so she serves as the antagonist. She stands for rigid logic, “truth” and conformity: she wants the oyster opened and Clay shown the facts, and she wants to change her looks to fit in. Importantly, she is not cruel; she simply lacks understanding at first. By the end her neat, changed appearance and bewildered silence show that Harry has softened her certainty.

The deeper opposing forces (**poverty**, money worries, and the quarrels between Clay’s parents) are the real obstacles of the story. They are symbolised by the oyster’s hard shell.

	Protagonist	Antagonist
Character	Harry Van Dusen	Miss McCutcheon (and the pressure of poverty)
Outlook	Faith, kindness, take it easy	Facts, rules, “face reality”
Aim	Protect Clay’s hope; help the family	Open the oyster; teach “truth”; fit in
Outcome	Succeeds; family moves toward reunion	Is softened; leaves puzzled

6. Plot Structure

The play follows the classic five-part structure (Freytag's pyramid) in a very compact form.

Stage	What happens in the play
Exposition	We meet Harry in his hat-filled barber shop, getting a haircut from Clay. His take-it-easy philosophy and the setting are introduced. Clay reveals that his father has gone and that the family has placed a newspaper advertisement. Miss McCutcheon, the new teacher, enters.
Inciting incident	Clay's statement that he wants money to bring his father home. This makes Harry care about the boy's problem and starts the main conflict.
Rising action	Harry refuses the poodle haircut. Clark visits secretly, leaves thirty dollars and takes the paper. The writer enters. Clay finds the oyster, and Miss McCutcheon demands it be opened. Harry sends for Wozzeck and explains the family's trouble. Conflict between fact and faith grows; Judge Applegarth adds humour.
Climax	The turning point: the writer buys the unopened oyster for three hundred dollars, declaring that the whole thing is a pearl. Clay keeps his belief and gets the money; the conflict is decided in Harry's favour.
Falling action	Clay leaves happily. Wozzeck is bewildered. Clark returns after seeing the advertisement and agrees to go home. Miss McCutcheon returns changed and is told there was a pearl. She leaves puzzled.
Denouement (resolution)	Clark decides not to desert his son, plans to take Clay fishing and invites Harry. Harry treats the oyster story as a joke on the teacher. The family is likely to be reunited and the shop returns to its calm, happy routine.

Conflicts in the play

- **Person vs person:** Harry against Miss McCutcheon over how to treat Clay (hope or hard facts).
- **Person vs circumstances:** Clay's family against poverty.
- **Person vs self:** Clark's shame and his struggle between leaving and returning.
- **Internal change:** Miss McCutcheon's loosening certainty.

7. Elements of the Play

Element	In The Oyster and the Pearl
Plot	A simple, unified story of one Saturday: from Clay's worry about his father to the sale of the oyster and Clark's decision to go home.
Characters	Round, believable people from a poor town. Harry (wise), Clay (hopeful), Miss McCutcheon (rational), Clark (ashamed but loving). Minor figures add colour.
Setting	One barber shop, one day, a small seaside town in 1953; unity of place and time.
Theme	Hope, faith, kindness and the idea that happiness lies in taking life easy.
Conflict	Faith versus fact; kindness versus rigid truth; family strain and poverty.
Dialogue	Natural, witty and philosophical. Harry's gentle humour reveals character and carries the story.
Symbolism	Oyster, pearl, sea, hats, the town's name and the poodle haircut carry deeper meaning.
Irony	The poorest town is called the richest; the teacher who teaches "truth" is beaten by a kind fiction; the oyster is never opened, yet everyone is enriched. Dramatic irony: the audience knows Clark was in the shop, but Clay does not.
Foreshadowing	Harry handing Clark the newspaper with the advertisement foreshadows his return.
Tone and mood	Light, humorous, warm and compassionate with a quiet sadness beneath.
Humour	The judge of "swine", Miss McCutcheon's poodle haircut, the haircut-less writer, Harry's endless hats.
Stage directions	Describe the cluttered shop, entrances and gestures, helping readers picture the scene.

8. Theme and Symbols

Main theme: take it easy, keep hope alive

Saroyan suggests that worry and strict logic cannot make life better, but warmth, humour and hope can. Harry has found peace by slowing down, and he tries to pass that attitude on to everyone he meets.

Other themes

- **Faith and hope over cold fact:** Clay's belief in the pearl is more valuable than the "truth" that Miss McCutcheon insists on.
- **Kindness and generosity:** Harry, Clark and the writer all give quietly, without seeking credit.
- **True wealth:** the townspeople are poor in money but rich in kindness, community and the beauty of the sea.
- **Family:** a father's pride and a boy's love can bring a divided family back together.
- **Individuality versus conformity:** Miss McCutcheon's wish for a poodle haircut shows how people try to fit in.

- **Imagination:** seeing the world as full of possibilities, as Greeley sees life in sea water.

Symbols

Symbol	Meaning
The oyster	Life's hardships and hidden possibilities. Its hard, closed shell shows how difficulties hide hope. It must be "believed in", not merely opened.
The pearl	Hope, faith and value that cannot be proved. For Clay it also means getting his father back.
The sea	Life itself – endless, mysterious, full of surprises (and the source of the town's small treasures).
Harry's hats	His relaxed, unconventional character and many moods.
O.K.-by-the-Sea	The town's name: life is not perfect, but it can be "O.K." when taken easy.
The poodle haircut	Conformity and hiding one's natural self to be taken seriously.
The newspaper advertisement	Hope of reconciliation; the bridge between Clay's family and Clark.
The three-legged chair	Miss McCutcheon's awkward attempt to join the town's way of life.

9. Questions and Answers

A. Short questions

Q1. Who is the protagonist of the play?

Harry Van Dusen, the barber, is the protagonist. He drives the action, protects Clay's hope and helps the Larrabee family.

Q2. Who is the antagonist?

Miss McCutcheon, who stands for strict logic and "truth". She is not a villain; she opposes Harry's outlook until her certainty is softened. Poverty is the deeper, impersonal opponent.

Q3. What is Harry Van Dusen's philosophy?

Harry believes in taking life easy. He says the trouble with his philosophy used to be that he kept forgetting to follow it, until he settled in O.K.-by-the-Sea.

Q4. Why does Clay want money?

Clay thinks money will help bring his father back home and let him buy his mother a present. His father left after quarrels over money.

Q5. What did Clay's father write before leaving?

He wrote a short message on the kitchen wall saying that enough was enough, which shows how worn out he felt.

Q6. Why does Harry refuse to give Miss McCutcheon a poodle haircut?

He feels she is trying to look like someone else. Her natural appearance already suits her, and he believes she should not change herself to fit in.

Q7. What does the oyster symbolise?

The oyster stands for life's difficulties and hidden hope. The hard shell is the obstacle; the pearl inside is hope or reward.

Q8. What does the pearl symbolise?

Hope, belief and the value of faith. For Clay, it is the chance of bringing his father home.

Q9. Why does Miss McCutcheon want the oyster opened?

She wants Clay to "face reality" and learn there is no pearl, believing children must be taught the truth early.

Q10. Why does Harry send for Wozzeck?

Harry wants a little time to arrange the money for Clay. Wozzeck is also the one who has pearls, so Harry's trick could be staged if needed.

Q11. Why does the writer buy the oyster?

He understands Harry's purpose. By paying three hundred dollars for the unopened oyster, he gives Clay the money and keeps his belief safe. For the writer "the whole thing is a pearl".

Q12. How does Clark come to return home?

He sees the family's newspaper advertisement, which Harry had handed him. This and his love for Clay make him decide to go home.

Q13. Why does Harry call the poor townspeople "the richest"?

They have no money but possess kindness, contentment, the sea and the hills. Harry values these above wealth.

Q14. What is the significance of the town's name?

O.K.-by-the-Sea suggests that life may not be perfect but is fine if one stays relaxed, which is Harry's philosophy.

Q15. What type of play is this?

A one-act comedy with a serious message, set in one place in a single day.

B. Long questions

Q1. Was it right for Harry to let Clay believe there was a pearl in the oyster? Explain.

Yes, because Harry's "lie" is an act of kindness, not deceit for gain. Clay is a poor boy who needs hope far more than a lesson in probability. Opening the oyster would only prove there was no pearl and would crush the one thing keeping him going. Harry does not seek profit; he wants Clay to have money and the courage to bring his father home. By letting the writer buy the oyster, he gives the boy both the money and his faith. Harry also tells Miss McCutcheon that people believe things "to keep going". Moreover, the family's real problem is not the pearl but the father's absence, and Harry's plan works toward that. So the gentle make-believe serves a deeper truth: hope can change real lives.

Q2. Write a character sketch of Harry Van Dusen.

Harry Van Dusen is the barber of O.K.-by-the-Sea and the wisest person in the play. He came to the town twenty-four years ago with almost nothing and found contentment. He always wears a hat, reads many books and keeps the sea's leftovers in his shop. He is humorous, observant and gentle. Money matters little to him; he gives haircuts for a quarter or for nothing. He knows everyone's troubles, and he helps quietly: he guards Clark's secret, hands him the paper, and sets up the oyster sale. He is also firm: he refuses Miss McCutcheon the poodle haircut because he respects her natural self. His philosophy, "take it easy", is the play's main message. Overall he is the symbol of wisdom, compassion and calm.

Q3. Write a character sketch of Miss McCutcheon. How does she change?

Miss McCutcheon is young, pretty, intelligent and determined. As a new teacher she feels unaccepted and thinks the children lack ambition. She trusts facts, logic and rules, and she believes in teaching "truth". Her wish for a poodle haircut reveals insecurity: she wants to look serious and fit in. She is not unkind, but she is rigid. After Harry explains Clay's situation, she softens. When she returns, she is neatly dressed, is told there was a pearl, and leaves bewildered but quieter. The change is slight, yet it shows that she is beginning to understand that people also need hope, not only facts.

Q4. What is the theme of the play? How is it presented?

The central theme is that hope, kindness and a relaxed attitude to life are more valuable than cold fact and wealth. Saroyan presents it through the oyster and the pearl: Clay believes in a pearl no one has seen, and the play shows that his faith changes lives. Harry's philosophy and the town's name support the theme. The contrast between Harry and Miss McCutcheon shows two attitudes: compassion and strict logic. The happy ending proves that kindness works. Other themes include family love, true riches and individuality.

Q5. Is the title *The Oyster and the Pearl* suitable?

Yes. The title points to the two symbols that hold the whole play together. The oyster stands for life's hard shell of troubles; the pearl stands for hope hidden inside. Everything in the plot – the dispute with Miss McCutcheon, the writer's purchase, Clark's return – revolves around the oyster. It also suggests that, like a pearl, human happiness is rare and precious and needs care to grow. The title is therefore both simple and meaningful.

Q6. Discuss irony in the play.

The play is rich in gentle irony. The town is poor yet called the richest by Harry. Miss McCutcheon, who stands for truth, is defeated by a kind fiction. The oyster is never opened, yet it produces a "pearl" worth three hundred dollars. There is dramatic irony too: the audience knows that Clark has been in the shop and that his thirty dollars waits for Clay, while Clay does not. And although Miss McCutcheon fears the children are careless, they show more wisdom and faith than she does.

C. Quick revision

- Writer: William Saroyan – American-Armenian dramatist (Pulitzer for *The Time of Your Life*, 1940, refused).
- Setting: Harry's barber shop, O.K.-by-the-Sea, California, 1953, one Saturday.
- Protagonist: Harry Van Dusen. Antagonist: Miss McCutcheon (outlook); poverty (circumstance).
- Climax: the writer buys the unopened oyster for three hundred dollars.
- Denouement: Clark decides to stay with his family; fishing trip planned.
- Symbols: oyster = hardship, pearl = hope, sea = life, name of town = life is O.K.
- Message: Hope and kindness are more valuable than cold facts and money.

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